

Bird of paradise leaf-curl field guide

A visual atlas and field tools for checking roots, exposure, and pests before changing care.



Three observations before the watering can

Leaf	Root ball	Exposure
New roll or mature curl?	Dry center, evenly moist, or wet?	Recent move, airflow, or visible pests?

24 pages • White bird of paradise is the primary subject. Illustrations are schematic; example measurements are not prescriptions.

Start with evidence

Follow the route that matches the pot and the plant—not curl direction alone.

Which leaf has changed?

New roll only

Record development without forcing the blade open. If tissue deteriorates, investigate. Atlas: page 4.

Previously open blade

Inspect the actual root ball and drainage. Do not decide from curl direction.

What does the root ball show?

Dry center

Rewet evenly; check bypass and crowding. Page 9.

Moist / uncertain

Moist: inspect exposure and pests. Uncertain: use the sampling map, page 8.

Wet + decline

Check runoff and roots; do not add a rescue drink. Page 10.

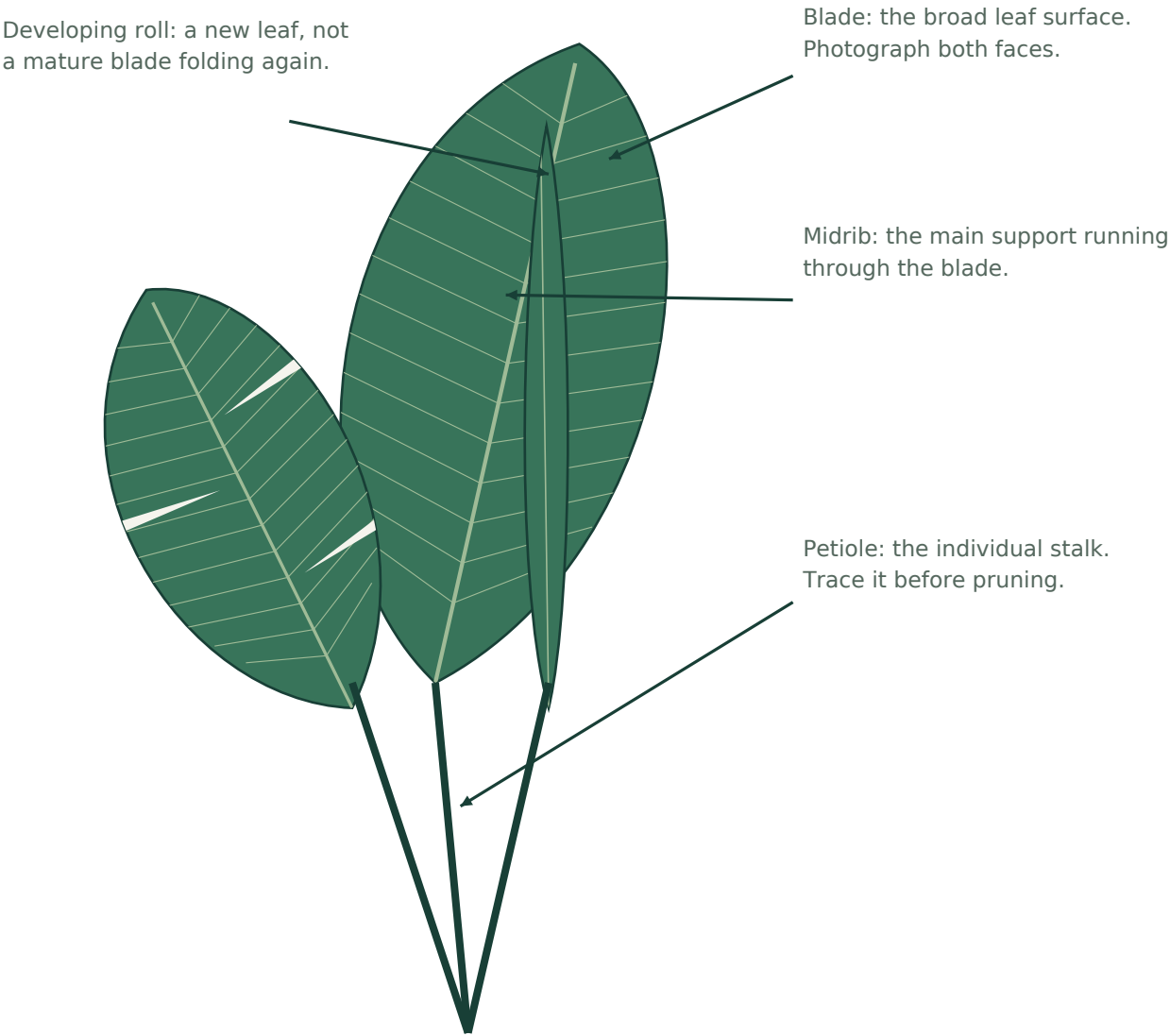
After the root-zone check

Inspect pests (pp. 14–15) and changed exposure (pp. 12–13). Choose a correction supported by evidence. Track fresh damage and later growth (p. 23).

Soft base, rapid spread or extensive root deterioration → prompt diagnostic help.

Know the parts you inspect

Name the structure first so you do not cut a new leaf or confuse the blade with its stalk.



White bird	Orange bird
Strelitzia nicolai: main scope of this guide; large-leaf indoor foliage plant.	Strelitzia reginae: separate species. Do not transfer every size, flowering or outdoor cold claim.

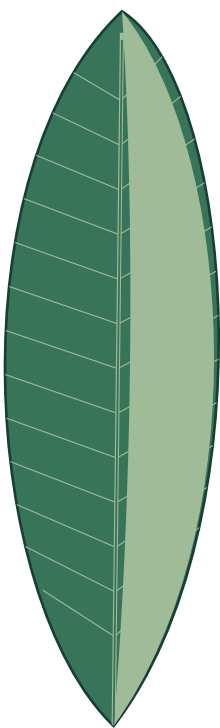
Atlas 1 • A roll is not always decline

Compare leaf history, not just the outline in one photograph.



Developing central roll

A new leaf has not completed expansion. Record its progress without pulling the blade apart.



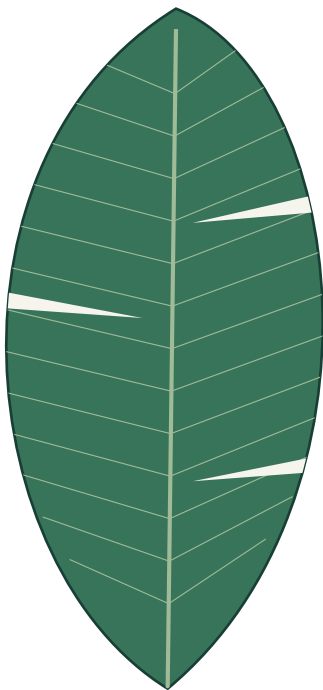
Previously open blade

A mature blade has changed shape. Check the root ball, exposure and underside; curl alone does not identify the cause.

Evidence to keep	What would change the route
Date and photo of the same new roll	Discoloration, tissue damage or visible pests → investigate rather than force it open.
Photo showing a previously open mature leaf	New curl or spreading discoloration → continue to root-zone checks.

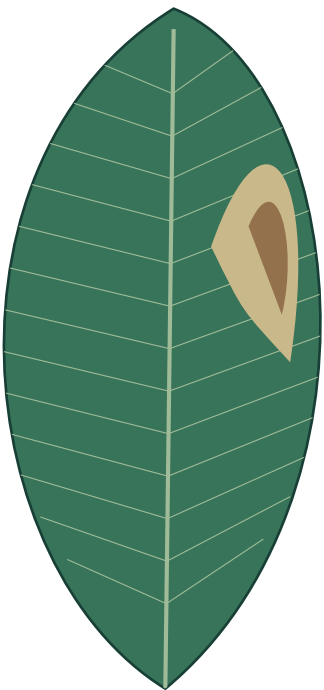
Atlas 2 • Breaks versus damaged tissue

A physical gap and a pale or dead patch require different follow-up checks.



Split, still-green blade

Look for wind, brushing, furniture contact or handling. A tear will not close after watering.



Pale / brittle patch

Compare recent sun and heat exposure. Stronger light after a move is a lead, not proof of the entire diagnosis.

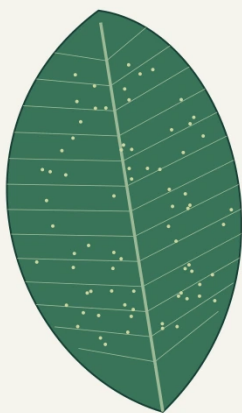
Check	Useful evidence
Distribution	Only the window-facing side? Only the side brushed past each day?
Root ball	Still check moisture. Exposure damage does not prove that the roots are dry.
Follow-up	Map new damage on previously unaffected tissue; old tears and dead patches remain in the record.

Sources 2, 9, 16 • Numbered references on page 24

Atlas 3 • Surface signs worth magnifying

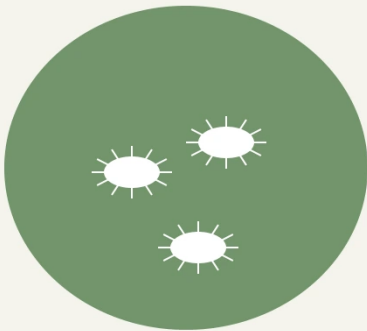
These drawings indicate inspection targets, not a confirmed diagnosis.

Look underneath before choosing a treatment



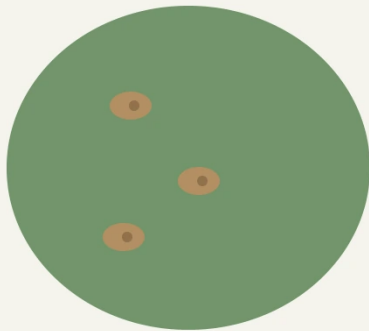
Stippling

Look for mites



Waxy clusters

Inspect crevices



Attached bumps

Check for scale

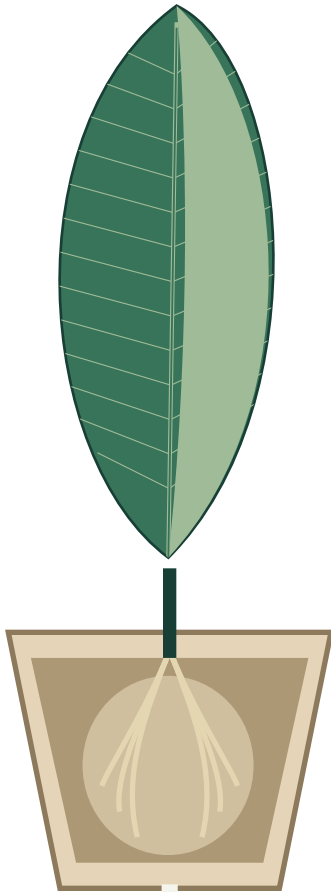
Enlarged schematics, not confirmed pest specimens.

Sign	Next confirming check
Tiny pale dots / bronzing	Underside + 10× lens; tap foliage over white paper and look for moving specks.
Cottony or waxy material	Inspect protected joints and undersides for mealybugs; photograph close detail.
Attached bumps / coverings	Inspect for scale rather than assuming every bump is a scar.
Webbing	Look for mites and feeding damage; distinguish loose dust and stray cobwebs.

Sources 12, 13 • Numbered references on page 24

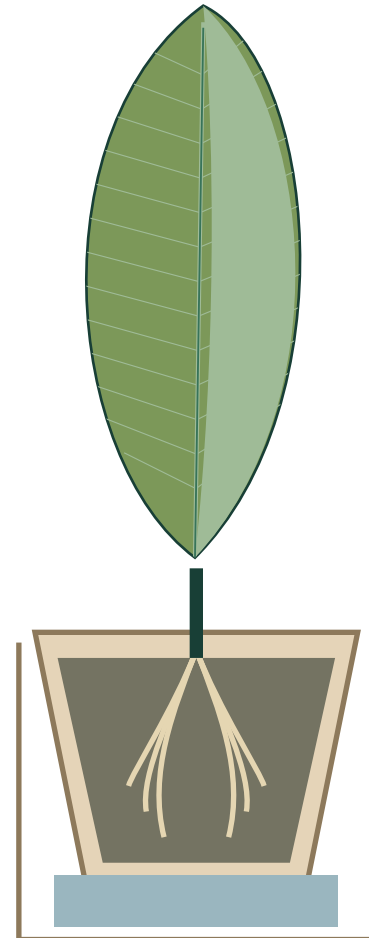
Atlas 4 • Similar leaves, different roots

A leaf-only photograph cannot settle the dry-pot versus wet-pot question.



Route A: dry root ball

Confirm the center is dry. Assess bypass and root crowding before choosing a rewetting method.



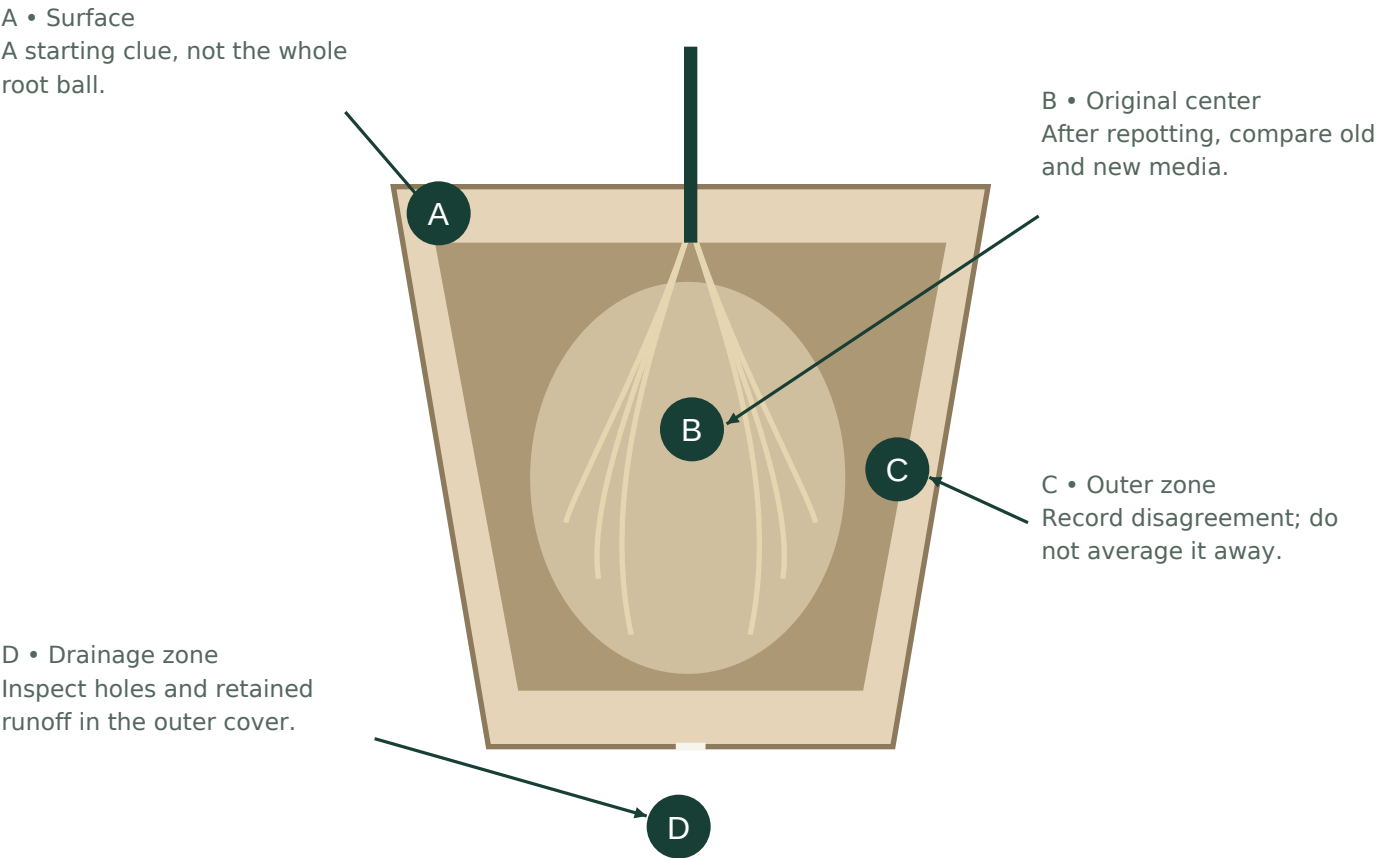
Route B: wet + decline

Check trapped runoff, drainage and root condition. Do not add water merely because the foliage is curled.

The next useful evidence is inside and below the growing pot. Continue to page 8.

Sample the root zone, not one spot

Use accessible observations gently. A large plant is not worth a lifting injury or torn roots.



Log entry	Example wording
Surface + center + edge	"Surface dry; accessible center dry; outer ring damp."
Drainage + relative weight	"Holes open; cover empty; lighter than familiar drained state."
Access limitation	"Large plant: lower center not safely accessible." Do not invent an observation.

Sources 5, 6 • Numbered references on page 24

The dry-center rewetting route

The objective is evenly moistened mix—not simply water appearing at a drain hole.

1 Confirm this route fits

Accessible checks support a dry center. A wet, heavy pot with progressive decline belongs on page 10.

2 Watch the first application

Apply slowly across the mix. Note whether water immediately bypasses the root ball down a side gap.

3 Recheck the center

For dry, water-repellent media, use slow repeated applications or a temporary soak where the pot is manageable. Then drain.

4 Remove collected runoff

Empty the saucer or cover. Do not leave the growing pot standing in a reservoir.

5 Investigate repeated failure

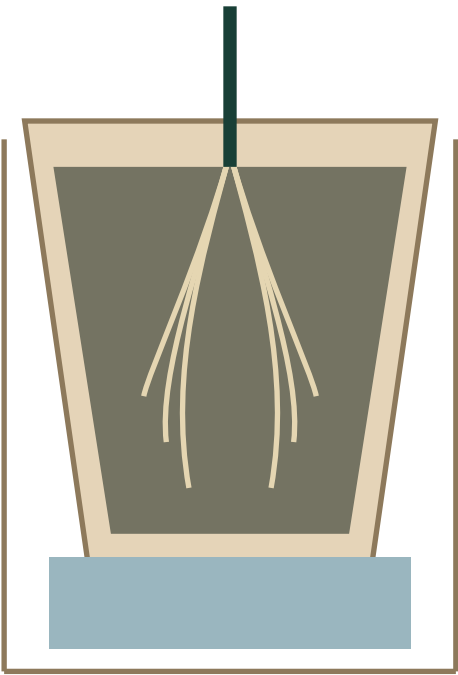
A repeatedly dry center or very fast dry-down warrants a root-occupancy and pot-fit check. Do not solve every recurrence with more frequent small drinks.

Record	Not a valid shortcut
Root ball before and after; application method; runoff behavior	"I watered yesterday, therefore the center is moist."
Root occupancy when a justified inspection is made	"It has been a year, therefore it needs a much bigger pot."

Sources 5, 6, 7 • Numbered references on page 24

The wet-pot triage sheet

Wilt in wet mix is not permission to water again. Inspect drainage and, when decline continues, root condition.



Firm tissue
Texture and integrity matter more than a color label alone.



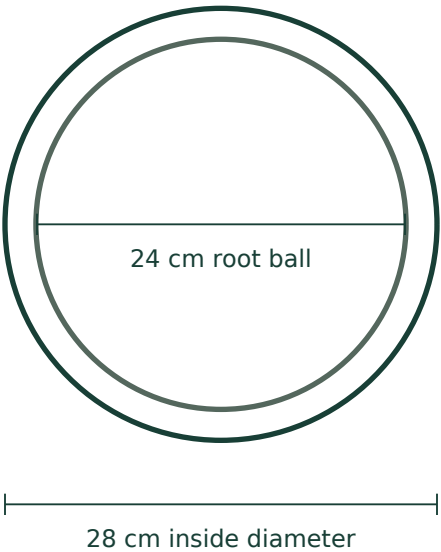
Soft / disintegrating tissue
Worsening wet-root decline requires a focused root assessment.

Immediate check	Evidence-led response
Standing runoff / blocked drainage	Remove retained water; establish actual drainage.
Persistently wet mix + worsening foliage	Inspect roots carefully rather than continuing “rescue” drinks.
Extensive soft roots or soft base	Seek plant-specific diagnostic help. A photograph cannot identify a pathogen.
Only old damage remains	Evaluate fresh damage and the corrected root-zone behavior.

Sources 4 • Numbered references on page 24

Measure pot fit before sizing up

These are geometry examples, not a prescribed pot size for your plant.



Radial clearance

$(\text{Inside diameter} - \text{root-ball diameter}) \div 2$

$(28 - 24) \div 2 = 2 \text{ cm per side}$

A 36 cm pot around the same root ball leaves 6 cm per side—three times the radial gap.

The volume grows faster than the diameter

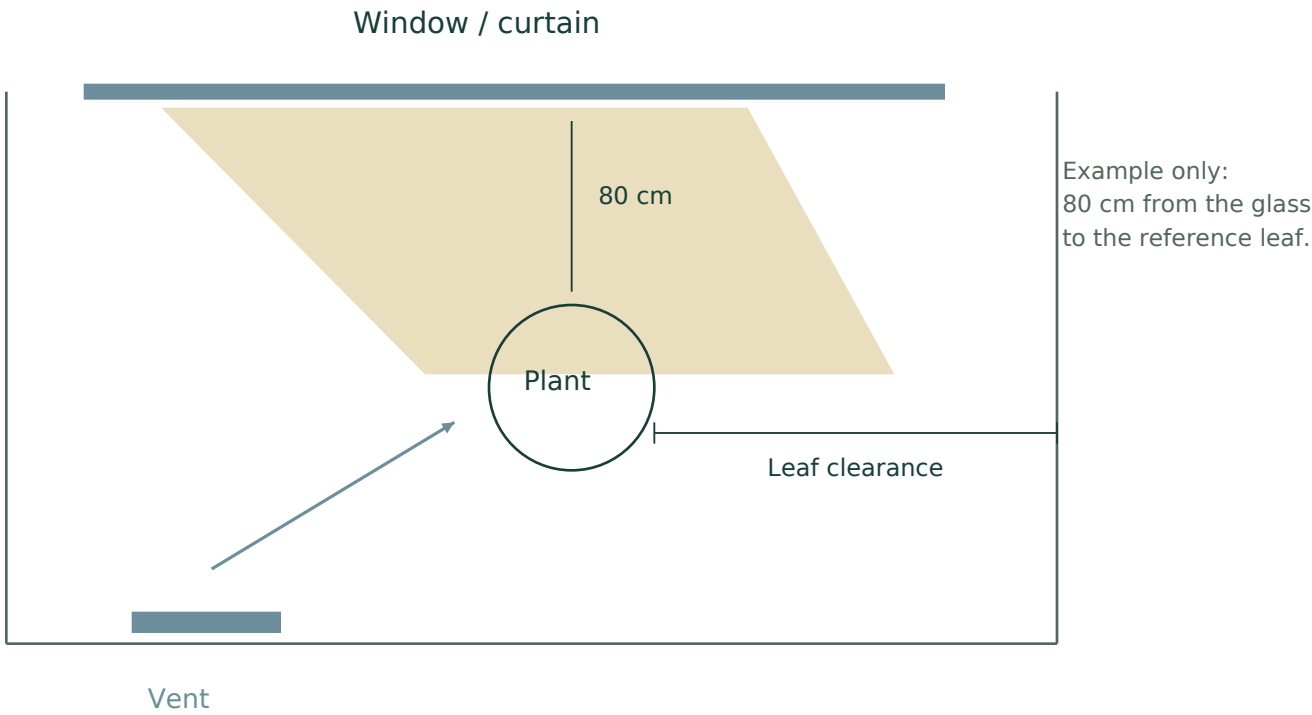
Simplified cylinders, same 24 cm height	Calculated volume
28 cm diameter: $\pi \times 14^2 \times 24 \div 1,000$	14.8 L
36 cm diameter: $\pi \times 18^2 \times 24 \div 1,000$	24.4 L
$(24.4 - 14.8) \div 14.8$, using unrounded values	About 65% more container volume

Real pots taper, roots occupy space, and fill height varies. These volumes explain why an oversized pot is not a small change; they are not the amount of mix or water to add.

Sources 3, 5 • Numbered references on page 24

Draw the room at leaf height

Placement measurements describe your room. They are not universal “feet from a window” rules.



Observation	Write the actual condition
Direct beam	Which leaf; what time; curtain open or closed?
Glass / furniture	Contact, clearance and the side brushed past.
Airflow	Heater, air-conditioning outlet, door or balcony wind.
Change to test	One justified adjustment, plus a same-angle photo before and after.

Measure a change, not a magic number

Take readings near the foliage without misting the sensor or relying only on a distant thermostat.

Fictional room log	Temperature	Relative humidity	Context
9 a.m.	71°F	43%	Heating off; curtain closed
3 p.m.	78°F	34%	Heating on; curtain open
9 p.m.	72°F	40%	Heating off; no sun

What this log establishes

Conditions vary with the recorded setup. It does not prove that 34% caused the curl or that every plant requires the same humidity percentage.

Temperature conversion check

$$^{\circ}\text{C} = (^{\circ}\text{F} - 32) \times 5 \div 9$$
$$65^{\circ}\text{F} \rightarrow 18.3^{\circ}\text{C} \quad \bullet \quad 85^{\circ}\text{F} \rightarrow 29.4^{\circ}\text{C}$$

NC State gives 65–85°F as a preferred white-bird range. This is cultivation guidance, not a sharp injury boundary. Rapid changes and drafts belong in the investigation.

A useful humidity intervention

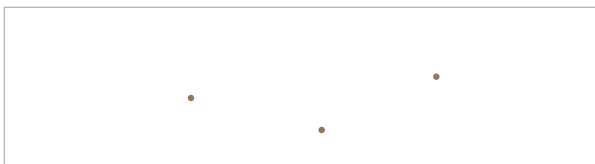
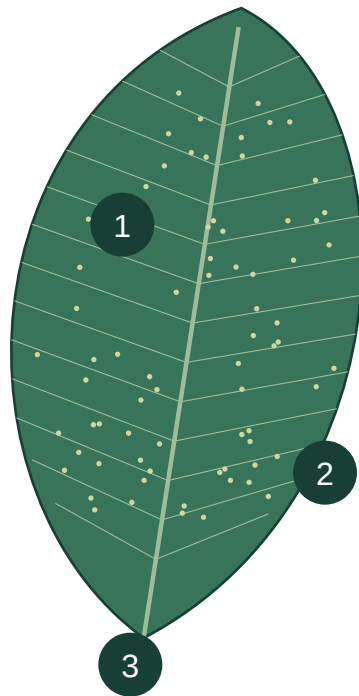
Where dry room air is a documented problem, a maintained humidifier provides a sustained change more effectively than repeated misting. Recheck the same location and context. Do not let the equipment wet the pot or sensor.

Record: instrument position • time • heating/cooling state • curtain position • intervention • next comparable reading.

Sources 2, 10, 11 • Numbered references on page 24

Run an underside inspection

Choose one damaged leaf and one reference leaf, then inspect protected joints.



Tap over white paper; observe whether specks move.
Photograph through a lens when possible.

1 Scan the blade

Look for stippling, marks and colonies using bright light.

2 Inspect the underside

Use a 10× lens. Check near veins and sheltered areas.

3 Check the joint

Look for waxy clusters and scale-like bumps in crevices.

Log the structure, side, pest-like sign, magnification and image filename. Keep a suspected infested plant away from neighboring foliage while identifying the organism.

Do not infer “no mites” solely because heavy webbing is absent.

Choose treatment from an identification

Keep the plant’s water stress and the product label in the decision.

Evidence	Next step	Do not substitute
Visible, identified pest; small accessible area	Supported wiping or rinsing; inspect the collection	A broad spray because a leaf curls
Persistent confirmed pest	Product labeled for the pest, plant and indoor site	A household detergent recipe
Water-stressed plant or excessive heat	Correct stress; follow application restrictions	Oils or soaps regardless of plant condition
Worsening unidentified damage	Diagnostic assistance and close photographs	Repeated changing products without identification

Read these five fields before application

1 Pest and site

Does the label name the organism and indoor use?

2 Plant eligibility

Check listed plants, exclusions and sensitivity testing.

3 Dilution and coverage

Use the label—not a social-media mix.

4 Repeat interval

Record the label interval and your actual application date.

5 Restrictions

Review temperature, stress, people/pets and protective measures.

Sources 12, 13 • Numbered references on page 24

Audit salts and water inputs

Deposits plus the input history are useful. A brown tip alone is not a water-quality diagnosis.

Evidence to collect	Example note	What it does not prove
Crystalline material	“White crust at rim and mix surface”	Not a pest identification
Water source	“Tap water; softener bypass status unknown”	Unknown is not sodium exposure
Fertilizer history	“Liquid feed plus pre-fertilized mix”	Not proof of deficiency
Mix and drainage	“Center stays wet; outer cover retains water”	Not a safe automatic flushing route

Separate the two routes

Freely draining, otherwise healthy roots	Persistently wet / declining roots
Review confirmed buildup and product instructions. A drainage-appropriate correction is different from routine extra watering.	Resolve retained water and root problems first. Do not repeatedly saturate a failing root ball to chase a crust.

Input record

Water source / softener route

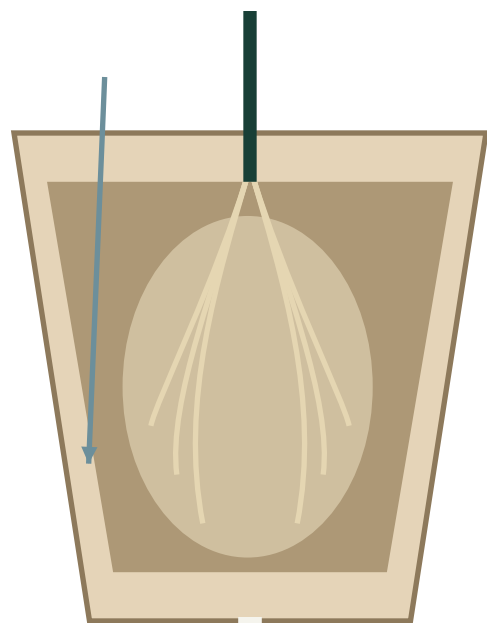
Fertilizer / dilution / last date

Mix / slow-release product

Do not feed a visibly stressed plant solely to “push out” a healthier leaf.

Case A • Runoff with a dry center

Fictional case, page 1 of 2. Use the evidence to choose the route.



Observation: green mature leaves curl. Water appears at the drain almost immediately. The inner pot is light compared with its familiar drained state.

Accessible center mix is dry; the outer ring is damp. No pest is found during the initial inspection.

Claim	Test
"Yesterday's watering rules out dryness."	Rejected: the center is still dry.
"Immediate runoff proves thorough watering."	Rejected: side bypass remains plausible.
"It needs a larger pot."	Unresolved: first document root occupancy.

Chosen route: slow rewetting, verify the center, drain completely, then assess crowding if the problem recurs.

Case A • Measure without inventing uptake

Fictional case, page 2 of 2. Water arithmetic describes the observation, not a dosing target.

Measured during this example	Amount
Water applied across the mix	900 mL
Runoff recovered during observation	250 mL
Applied – recovered runoff	650 mL

900 – 250 = 650 mL not recovered as runoff

Do not label 650 mL “water absorbed by the roots.” It includes water retained in the medium and any unmeasured losses. The same applied amount would not be an instruction for a different plant.

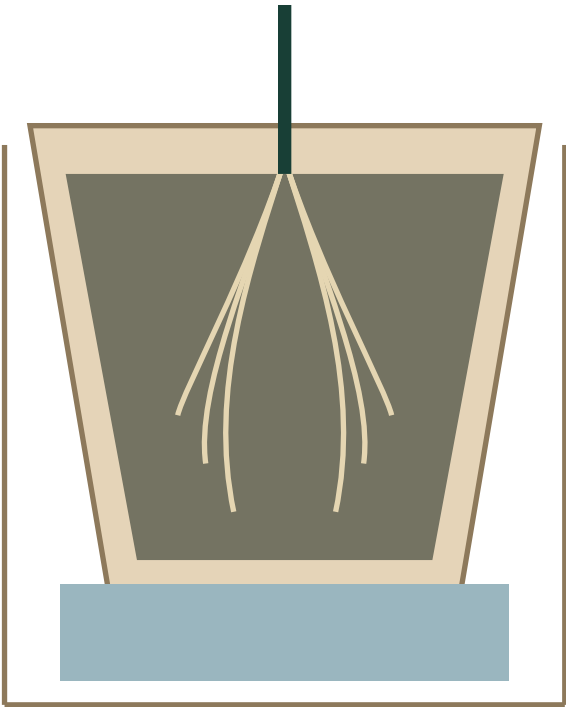
Action and next evidence

After the focused correction	How the next decision changes
Center now moist; outer pot empty	Keep observing the actual dry-down; do not add another drink just to flatten a leaf.
Center still dry despite side runoff	Continue the rewetting investigation; assess accessible root occupancy and medium condition.
Decline continues while root ball stays wet	Switch to the wet-root investigation rather than intensifying the dry-pot treatment.

Record the application method, center/edge findings, runoff and a same-angle leaf photograph. Those details explain more than “watered well.”

Case B • The cover hides a reservoir

Fictional case, page 1 of 2. The decorative container is part of the diagnosis.



Observation: mature leaves curl and yellowing progresses. The inner pot remains heavy, and lower accessible mix is wet.

Inspection: runoff remains below the growing pot inside a decorative cover. Drainage performance and root condition have not yet been established.

Known	Still unknown
Water is retained beneath the pot.	How extensive the root injury is, if any.
Mix is wet while decline continues.	Whether a pathogen is present; which organism.
A small rescue drink adds more water.	Which focused root correction is appropriate.

Chosen route: remove retained water, establish drainage and inspect roots when continuing decline justifies it.

Case B • Let root findings choose the action

Fictional case, page 2 of 2. A leaf photograph cannot replace the root observation.

Inspection finding	Decision	Record
Roots remain firm; drainage defect found	Correct the defect and manage actual moisture, not the leaf outline.	Defect, correction and subsequent dry-down.
Some soft or disintegrating roots	A focused root recovery assessment is justified.	Texture, distribution and photographs before intervention.
Extensive root deterioration or a soft base	Seek prompt plant-specific diagnostic help.	Whole plant, base, root ball, care history.
Old damage stays visible; no new damage found	Do not add another treatment solely to erase old damage.	Same reference leaves and comparable images.

Give the diagnostic service useful evidence

Include the inner and outer pot setup, repotting date, recent watering, light changes, root texture and progression of symptoms. Preserve the original photographs rather than sending only the newest worst-looking leaf.

Do not turn an observation into a label

“Wet mix plus soft roots” is evidence. Naming a specific fungus or oomycete requires more than these symptoms. Do not select a fungicide from the photograph alone.

Success measure: the identified drainage/root problem is addressed and fresh decline stops—not every old leaf becoming perfect.

Case C • A change in window exposure

Fictional case. Root moisture remains appropriate; new damage maps to the exposed side.

Sequence	Evidence	Meaning
Before move	Sheer curtain; stable reference photos	Known starting condition
After move	Direct afternoon beam reaches the same blades	A testable exposure change
New observation	Pale, brittle patches on window-facing leaves	Supports an exposure investigation
Root-zone check	Appropriate moisture; no trapped runoff	Not a reason for another drink

Focused correction

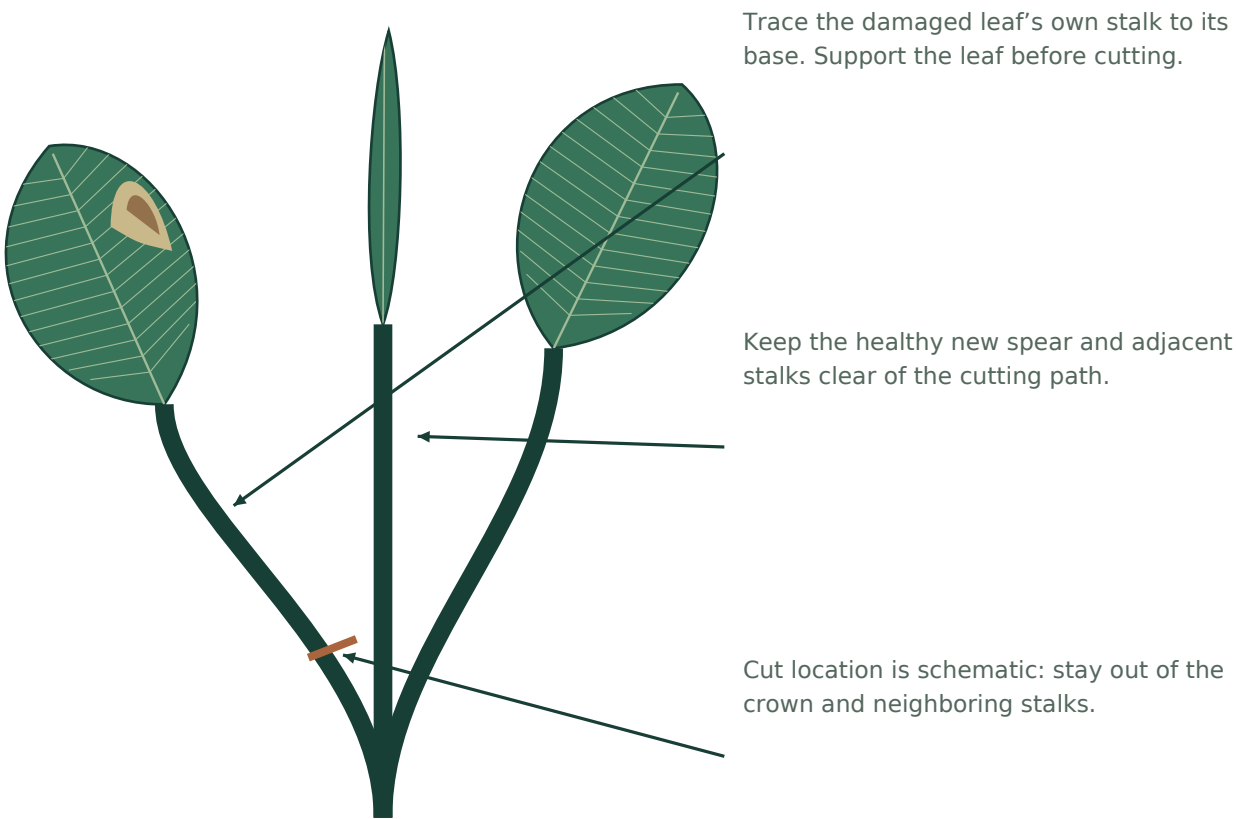
Restore filtered exposure and remove contact with hot glass. Measure near the foliage at the observed warm period. Keep the rest of the care record stable enough to interpret what follows.

What would change the decision?

Next observation	Follow-up
New damage spreads beyond the exposed side	Recheck roots and pests; do not force every symptom into the sun story.
No fresh damage; old patch remains	Keep the record. Dead tissue is not restored by watering.
A later outdoor move is planned	Use gradual acclimation and wind shelter, not a sudden all-day exposure.

Remove a leaf without injuring the crown

Selective removal is for justified dead or badly damaged foliage—not every green curled blade.



Before the cut	After the cut
Clean, sharp tool; stable footing; leaf supported; own stalk identified.	Remove debris, keep the usable green foliage, and return to the evidence-led care correction.

Track new damage, not perfection

A small repeatable record is more useful than repeatedly changing the care.

Reference / date	Existing damage	New finding	Next action
A / first photo	Mature curl; green	Baseline only	Check pot and underside
A / repeat photo	Same visible curl	No additional damage found	Keep correction; record moisture
B / repeat photo	Old split	New pale patch on sun side	Recheck exposure history

An observation count, not a severity score

Example: 3 of 10 tracked mature leaves developed additional damage.

$3 \div 10 \times 100 = 30\%$ of the tracked leaves.

This describes this sample only. It is not a treatment threshold, a forecast, or a percentage of the whole plant’s health. Keep leaf identity and the definition of “new damage” consistent.

Your next repeatable check

Reference leaf / photo

Center / edge / drainage

Change made / date

New finding / next route

Prompt diagnostic help: soft base, rapid spread, extensive root deterioration, or a persistent unidentified pest. Provide the evidence, not just a close-up.

Source key and next resources

Source numbers on each page link the care guidance to extension and horticultural references.

1. New Hampshire — Houseplant Winter Care Q&A
2. NC State — *Strelitzia nicolai*
3. RHS — How to grow *Strelitzia*
4. Iowa State — Root Rots of Houseplants
5. Maryland — Pot-Bound Indoor Plants
6. Maryland — Watering Indoor Plants
7. Iowa State — How to Care for Houseplants
8. Maryland — Lighting for Indoor Plants
9. Maryland — Excess Light on Indoor Plants
10. Maryland — Temperature and Humidity for Indoor Plants
11. Iowa State — Should I mist houseplants in dry winter air?
12. UC IPM — Spider Mites
13. Minnesota — Managing insects on indoor plants
14. Maryland — Mineral and Fertilizer Salt Deposits on Indoor Plants
15. RHS — Leaf damage on houseplants
16. RHS — Wind scorch
17. NC State — *Strelitzia reginae*
18. RHS — *Strelitzia alba* subsp. *nicolai* plant profile

Continue with the matched Novel Plants tools

Root-zone watering routine • Repotting without overpotting
Bringing plants indoors • White bird of paradise • Indoor plants

Research checked September 28, 2026. Original diagrams and fictional worked cases by Novel Plants. No product doses, guaranteed recovery times, or species-specific humidity thresholds are inferred.